FUTURES MATTER EDUCATION

Futures Matter - Northwood, 122 Emily Street, Highgate, Birmingham, B12 0XJ

Accessibility Plan

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1.0 AIMS

Under the Equality Act 2010, every school must have an accessibility plan. This plan sets out how Futures Matter - Northwood will:

- increase the extent to which pupils with disabilities can take part in the curriculum
- improve the physical environment of the school so that pupils with disabilities can take better advantage of the education, benefits, facilities and services we provide
- improve the availability of accessible information for pupils with disabilities
- offer additional support to meet the needs of families of young carers, by making sure the school is accessible and welcoming to parents and carers with disabilities or illness, and by removing barriers to communication

All of our pupils are aged 11 to 16, have an EHC plan, and have social, emotional and mental health needs, autism, or both. Many also have communication, sensory, learning or medical needs. Accessibility at Futures Matter is therefore not only about ramps and lifts. It is about the sensory environment, how we communicate, predictable routines, and the way we adapt the curriculum so that every pupil can take part and make progress.

We aim to treat all pupils and their families fairly and with respect. We want our school to be welcoming to parents, carers and visitors who have disabilities or illness, including those who are young carers or who care for a family member.

We involve pupils, parents and carers, and staff in developing this plan. We ask pupils for their views in ways that suit their communication needs, and we ask parents and carers at EHC plan reviews, parents' meetings and by survey. The Proprietor and the School Governance Board are also consulted.

The plan is published on our website, and paper copies are available on request from the school office. Our SEND Policy refers to it, and our Complaints Policy covers it: any concern about accessibility can be raised under that policy. We train staff in equality issues under the Equality Act 2010, including understanding disability, and we use any partnerships that are available to help us carry out the plan.

2.0 LEGISLATION AND GUIDANCE

This plan meets the requirements of Schedule 10 of the Equality Act 2010 and takes account of the Department for Education (DfE) guidance on the Equality Act 2010 for schools. It is also based on the following:

- The Special Educational Needs and Disability (SEND) Code of Practice
- The Children and Families Act 2014
- The DfE guidance Supporting pupils at school with medical conditions
- The Equality and Human Rights Commission (EHRC) technical guidance for schools in England
- Best practice guidance on supporting young carers in schools

The Equality Act 2010 defines a person as disabled if they have a physical or mental impairment that has a 'substantial' and 'long-term' adverse effect on their ability to carry out normal day-to-day activities. The SEND Code of Practice defines 'long-term' as a year or more, and 'substantial' as more than minor or trivial. The definition includes sensory impairments, such as those affecting sight or hearing, and long-term health conditions, such

as asthma, diabetes, epilepsy and cancer. Many of our pupils have needs that meet this definition, including autism and mental health conditions.

Schools are required to make 'reasonable adjustments' for pupils with disabilities, to alleviate any substantial disadvantage that they would otherwise face compared with pupils without disabilities. This can include providing an auxiliary aid or making adjustments to premises. The duty is anticipatory: we think ahead about what pupils are likely to need, and we do not wait for a particular pupil to be disadvantaged. As an independent school, the Proprietor is the responsible body for this plan.

3.0 ACTION PLAN

The action plan sets out our approach to the four aims above. It covers the school years 2026 to 2027 onwards. For each aim it records what we do now, our objectives, the actions we will take, who is responsible, when they will be done, and how we will know they have worked. The plan builds on the work started by Louise De-Hayes in 2025 to 2026, with the measures that apply to a school of our size and setting. The first action under Aim 2 is an accessibility audit of the whole building (Appendix 1), and the results will be used to finish and update the plan.

3.1 Aim 1: Increase access to the curriculum

Aim 1	Increase access to the curriculum for pupils with a disability
Current good practice	Every pupil has an EHC plan, and the outcomes in it shape their timetable and targets. We use individual risk assessments and Positive Behaviour Support Plans to adapt what we do for each pupil. Pupils are taught in small groups, and lessons are adapted to each pupil's needs, including their communication, sensory and processing needs. Progress is tracked for every pupil, including pupils with a disability, and targets are set to suit the pupil's needs. Pupils with medical needs have an Individual Healthcare Plan. The curriculum is reviewed to make sure it meets the needs of all pupils.
Objectives	Short term (autumn 2026): make sure the IT that pupils use is accessible, and that all staff know the reasonable adjustments expected in every classroom. Medium term (by summer 2027): involve pupils and staff in reviewing the curriculum, physical activity and the personal development curriculum. Long term (by 2029): extra-curricular activities are accessible to all pupils, and every policy has been checked for its impact on pupils with disabilities.

Aim 1	Increase access to the curriculum for pupils with a disability
Actions to be taken	Review the accessibility of IT (including Chromebooks and smart boards) using specialist advice, involve pupils in the review of hardware and software, and prioritise software to buy. Train teaching and support staff on specialist resources, such as symbol-supported text (for example Communicate in Print). Circulate the reasonable adjustments classroom checklist to all staff, and check that classrooms and resources are organised to suit pupils' needs. Run a programme of staff training in disability awareness, with a focus on autism and sensory needs, and on our anticipatory duties. Collect feedback from pupils through a pupil survey and pupil voice, and from staff, on whether learning environments work for them. Review physical activity, PE and the personal development and healthy living curriculum for access. Audit who takes part in extra-curricular activities and visits, and the barriers to taking part. Make sure activities are accessible, with extra staff where needed, and seek advice on accessible venues for residential visits. Train staff in risk assessment for trips and activities, using our Risk Assessments Policy and Educational Visits Policy. Check the impact on pupils with disabilities of the Behaviour Policy, Restrictive Interventions Policy, Anti-Bullying Policy, Educational Visits Policy, homework and health provision, and consult pupils and staff on any changes.
Person responsible	Head Teacher (who also has the SENCo duties) for the curriculum, training and policy checks. Proprietor for any spend on IT and software. Tutors and support staff for the classroom checklist.
Date to complete by	IT review: autumn term 2026. Classroom checklist and disability awareness training: autumn term 2026, then each year. Physical activity and personal development review: spring term 2027. Extra-curricular audit: spring term 2027. Policy impact checks: each policy at its yearly review, from autumn 2026.
Success criteria	Every pupil can use the IT and software they need, and staff say they feel confident to use it. All classrooms meet the checklist. All staff have had disability awareness training in the year. Pupils' survey results show that they feel they can take part in lessons and activities. No pupil is left out of an activity because of a barrier we could have removed. Each policy review records its impact on pupils with disabilities.

3.2 Aim 2: Improve and maintain access to the physical environment

To confirm: the Head Teacher and the Proprietor to complete the building audit in Appendix 1, then fill in the current practice and targets for this aim.

Aim 2	Improve and maintain access to the physical environment
Current good practice	To be completed after the accessibility audit (Appendix 1). The school is based at 122 Emily Street, Highgate, in a converted building owned by a landlord. The audit will record what is already in place, including seating, ramps, lifts, corridor widths, parking, toilets and changing facilities, and the sensory environment, such as lighting, noise and space to regulate. We have personal evacuation plans for pupils who need them as part of their individual risk assessments and our fire arrangements.
Objectives	Short term (autumn 2026): complete the audit of the building and grounds, and make sure every pupil who needs one has a personal evacuation plan. Medium term (by summer 2027): make the changes that can be done quickly, improve signage, and decide on a low arousal space. Long term (by 2029): carry out the larger changes agreed with the landlord, within the budget set by the Proprietor.
Actions to be taken	Carry out the accessibility audit (Appendix 1) of the whole site, with the Head Teacher, the Proprietor and, where changes affect the structure, the landlord. Review personal evacuation plans for pupils, staff and visitors who may need help to leave the building, and practise them in fire drills. Identify accessible outdoor and play equipment, and involve pupils in designing the outdoor area. Look at whether a low arousal space is possible, and what it would need. Improve signage for evacuation procedures, online safety and fire drills, using symbols as well as words, and review the signage on the function of each room. Include accessibility in the Health and Safety Policy site checks.
Person responsible	Head Teacher as Health and Safety lead for the audit, evacuation plans and signage. Proprietor for budget and for agreeing changes with the landlord.
Date to complete by	Audit: autumn term 2026. Personal evacuation plans: December 2026, then each year. Signage: spring term 2027. Low arousal space feasibility: summer term 2027. Outdoor area: summer term 2027.
Success criteria	The audit is complete and the actions from it are in this plan. Every pupil, member of staff or visitor who needs a personal evacuation plan has one, and it has been tried in a drill. Signs use symbols and are easy to see. A decision on a low arousal space has been made and recorded. Pupils and staff say the building works for them.

3.3 Aim 3: Improve the delivery of information

Aim 3	Improve the delivery of information for pupils and families
Current good practice	We use a range of ways to share information with pupils and parents and carers, so that it is accessible. These include talking with families in person and by phone, written letters and emails, and information adapted for the pupil's communication needs. Many pupils have communication and processing needs, and we adapt information for them, for example with symbols, simple language, visual timetables and plain English.
Objectives	Short term (spring 2027): find out which formats pupils and families need. Medium term (summer 2027): documents are available in other formats when asked for, and newsletters and letters are easy to read. Long term (by 2029): the use of other formats is reviewed each year.
Actions to be taken	Make documents available in large print, audio, symbols, other languages and other formats when asked for. Use symbol-supported text software for information for pupils. Ask families when their child joins, and at each EHC plan review, whether they need information in another format. Review how easy to read our newsletters and letters to parents are, and keep them in plain English. Provide homework and curriculum information as information sheets in other formats when needed. Monitor how many documents are asked for in other formats, and what the feedback is.
Person responsible	Finance and Business Support Manager and the school office for the formats. Head Teacher for the review of information for pupils.
Date to complete by	Spring term 2027 for the first review, then each summer term.
Success criteria	Every family has been asked about the formats they need. Documents are provided in other formats within a week of a request. Feedback from families shows that our letters and newsletters are easy to understand.

3.4 Aim 4: Support young carers and families with a disability or illness

Aim 4	Offer additional support to meet the needs of young carers and their families
Current good practice	We know our families well, and we are in regular contact with parents and carers. We aim to be welcoming to parents and carers with disabilities or illness, and to remove barriers to taking part in school life.

Aim 4	Offer additional support to meet the needs of young carers and their families
Objectives	Short term (autumn 2026): find out which pupils are young carers, and which parents and carers have access needs. Medium term (by summer 2027): meetings and events can be attended by everyone who wants to. Long term (by 2029): families with caring responsibilities report that they feel supported.
Actions to be taken	Ask families when a pupil joins, and each year, whether they have access needs or caring responsibilities, and record this on the pupil's file. Offer different ways to attend meetings and events, such as home visits, phone or video calls, and different times of day. Make sure parents' meetings, EHC plan reviews and events are held in accessible rooms. Tell staff which pupils are young carers, so they can offer support and make sure their needs are heard. Tell families about local support for young carers and for carers.
Person responsible	Head Teacher and the school office. The Head Teacher, as DSL, makes sure any safeguarding concern about a young carer is dealt with under the Safeguarding and Child Protection Policy.
Date to complete by	Autumn term 2026, then each year.
Success criteria	All families have been asked about access needs and caring responsibilities. No parent or carer is prevented from attending a meeting because of a disability or illness. Families who have caring responsibilities say they feel supported.

3.5 Promoting positive attitudes to disability

Alongside the four aims, we promote positive attitudes to disability. In the first year we will review the personal development curriculum and assembly programme so that they celebrate difference, involve local disability groups where we can in assemblies and visits, and show the achievements of pupils with disabilities in our newsletter. The Head Teacher is responsible, and the review is due in the spring term 2027. We will have succeeded when pupils tell us in the pupil survey that the school respects difference.

4.0 MONITORING ARRANGEMENTS

The Head Teacher reviews progress against this plan each year, and reports to the School Governance Board. The plan is written again every 3 years, and may be reviewed and updated sooner if necessary, for example when the audit is finished, when the building changes, or when a pupil joins who has a need we have not planned for. The Proprietor and the Chair of the Board approve the plan.

5.0 LINKS WITH OTHER POLICIES

This accessibility plan is linked to the following policies and documents:

- Risk Assessments Policy

- Health and Safety Policy
- SEND Policy
- Supporting Pupils with Medical Conditions Policy
- Educational Visits Policy
- Anti-Bullying Policy
- Complaints Policy
- Safeguarding and Child Protection Policy
- Admissions Policy

References: Schedule 10 of the Equality Act 2010; DfE, The Equality Act 2010 and schools; SEND Code of Practice; EHRC technical guidance for schools in England.

6.0 APPENDICES

Appendix 1: Accessibility Audit

APPENDIX 1: ACCESSIBILITY AUDIT

Use this audit to find barriers to access and to decide what to do about them. Walk the building and grounds, and ask pupils, parents and carers, and staff. Record what you find, what we do already, and any action, who will do it and by when. The results go into the action plan in section 3.

ACCESSIBILITY AUDIT - to be completed by the Head Teacher with the Proprietor	
Entrance, parking, drop-off point and the route into the building (disabled parking bays, ramps, steps, door widths, signage):	
Corridors, stairs and lifts, and how a person who uses a wheelchair or has a mobility need moves between floors and rooms:	
Teaching rooms: seating, space to move, lighting, noise, and sensory needs, including quiet or low arousal spaces:	
Toilets, changing facilities and any area for personal care:	
Emergency evacuation: alarms (sound and visual), escape routes, refuge points, and personal evacuation plans:	
Outdoor areas and equipment, and signage (clear, large enough, symbols as well as words):	
Learning resources, library, IT and software: can pupils reach and use them, and do they include examples of people with disabilities?	
Information for pupils and families: large print, audio, symbols, translated and other formats:	
School events, parents' meetings and EHC plan reviews: are the rooms and times accessible to everyone, including parents and carers with disabilities or illness?	
Young carers and families with caring responsibilities: what do we know and how do we support them?	
Views of pupils, parents and carers, and staff on barriers they face:	

Summary of actions agreed and who is responsible, and the name, role and date of the person completing the audit:	